CSH interview: final preparation pack

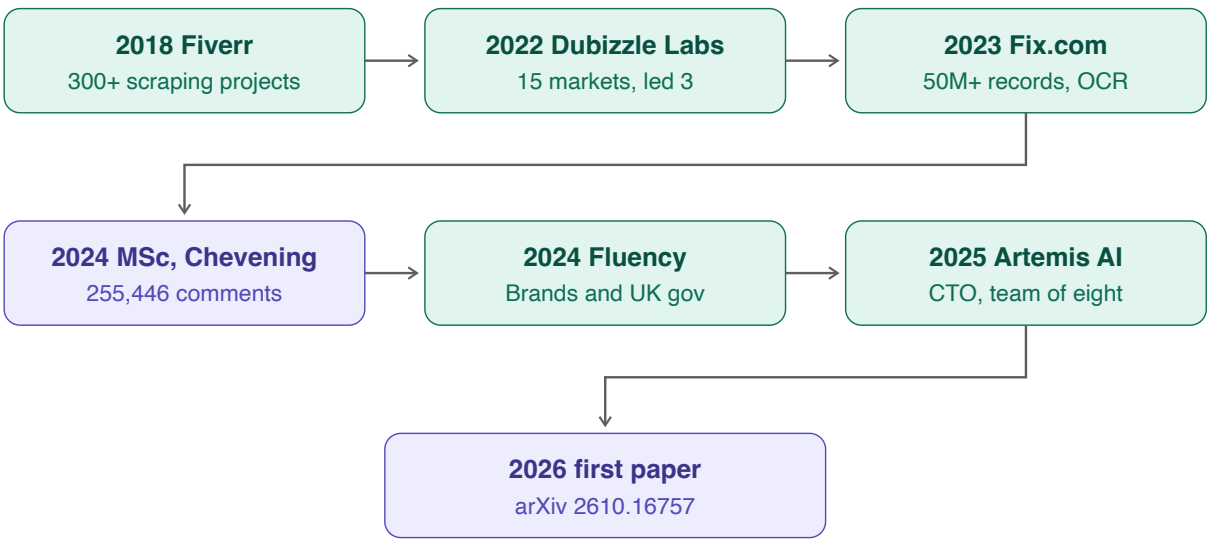
Preliminary interview **Tue 20 Oct 2026, 4:40–4:55 pm UK = 8:40 pm Lahore** · Zoom 843 5332 6447 · Graduate Program in Complexity Science, Digital Innovation School · interviewer contact: Carrie Cowan, Head of DIS

1. How this interview works (researched)

- **Format:** about 10 minutes of standard questions on your prior experience and future interests, plus a few minutes of instructions; in English on Zoom. CSH does not share questions in advance and says there is no need to prepare or study.
- **It counts:** the recording and transcript become part of your application package and are read by the Selection Committee alongside your written answers. So keep every fact consistent with what you submitted.
- **What the committee looks for** (CSH FAQ): fit between your background and CSH research, and "potential for independent and rigorous scholarship in the area of complexity science".
- **After this:** Stage 1 committee review → Stage 2 panel interview on Zoom, 7–14 January 2027, where you present a paper chosen by the committee and answer questions on it → Stage 3 finalists present their research ideas at CSH, 15–16 February → offers by mid-March. Referee letters must arrive by **1 November**.
- **What good answers look like** (PhD interview guides): specific, concrete examples of what you did; a clear reason for a PhD that comes from a real experience, not a slogan; naming their work that moved you; and showing gaps as things you are already learning.

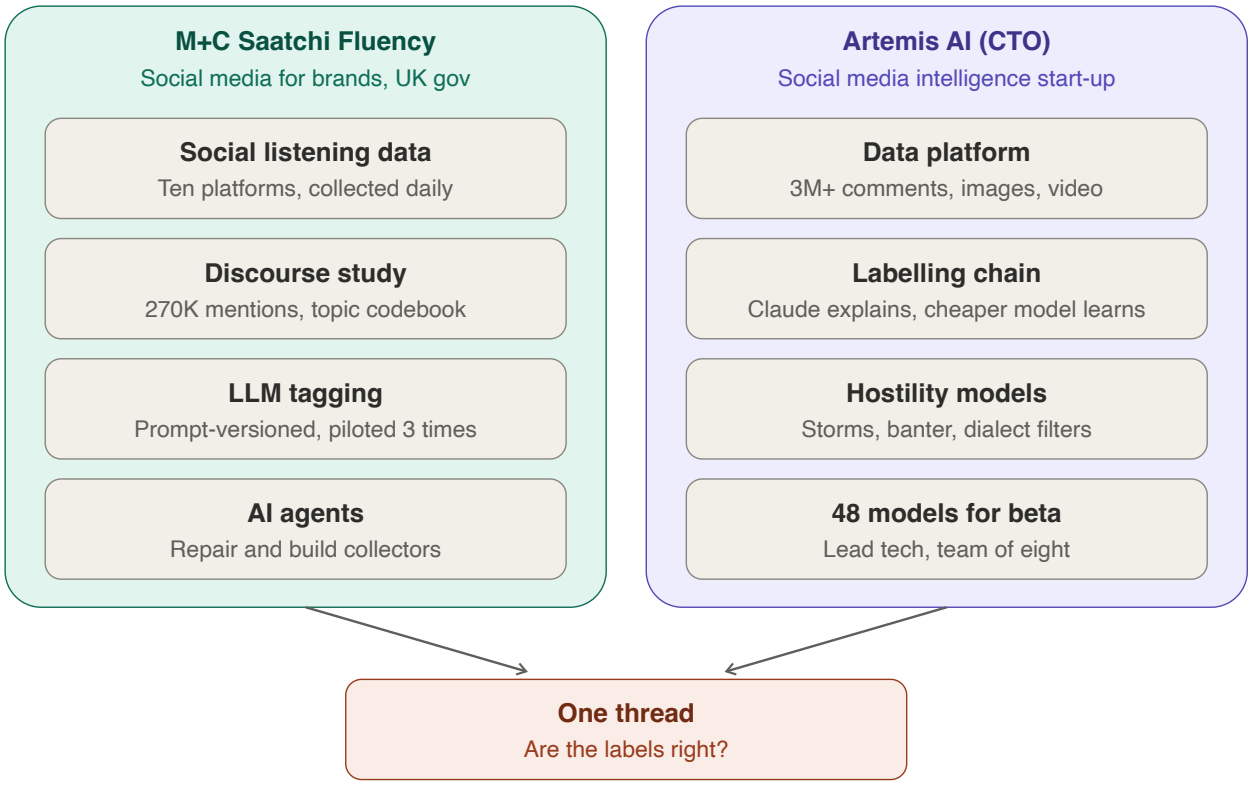
Three things to land in any answer.
Question: do machine and LLM labels of online text mean the same thing across platforms, models and time, and how do we correct comparisons when they do not?
Proof: your first paper, with Dr Ella Haig, on arXiv since 14 October (2610.16757), which grew from your dissertation's circular validation.
Edge: eight years collecting and labelling social media at scale (Dubizzle, Fluency, Artemis AI); data is never your bottleneck.

2. Your path, 2018 to 2026



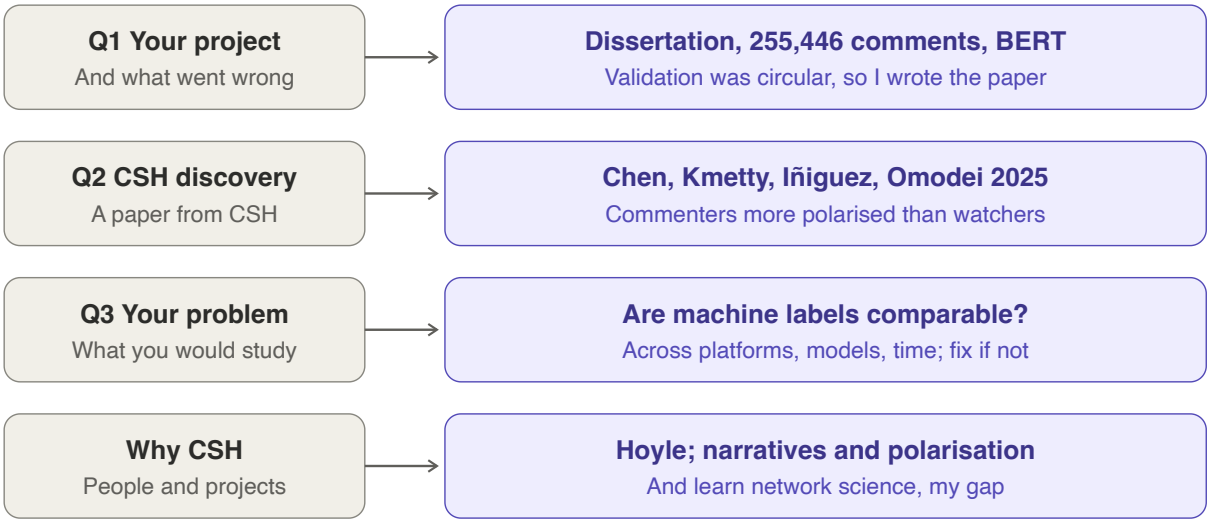
Teal = industry, purple = academic. Fiverr taught scraping and clients; Dubizzle multilingual data and leading people; Fix.com data quality at scale; MSc research method and honest validation; Fluency social media analysis that decisions rely on; Artemis AI building and evaluating models; the paper turned a weakness into research.

3. What you did at Fluency and Artemis AI



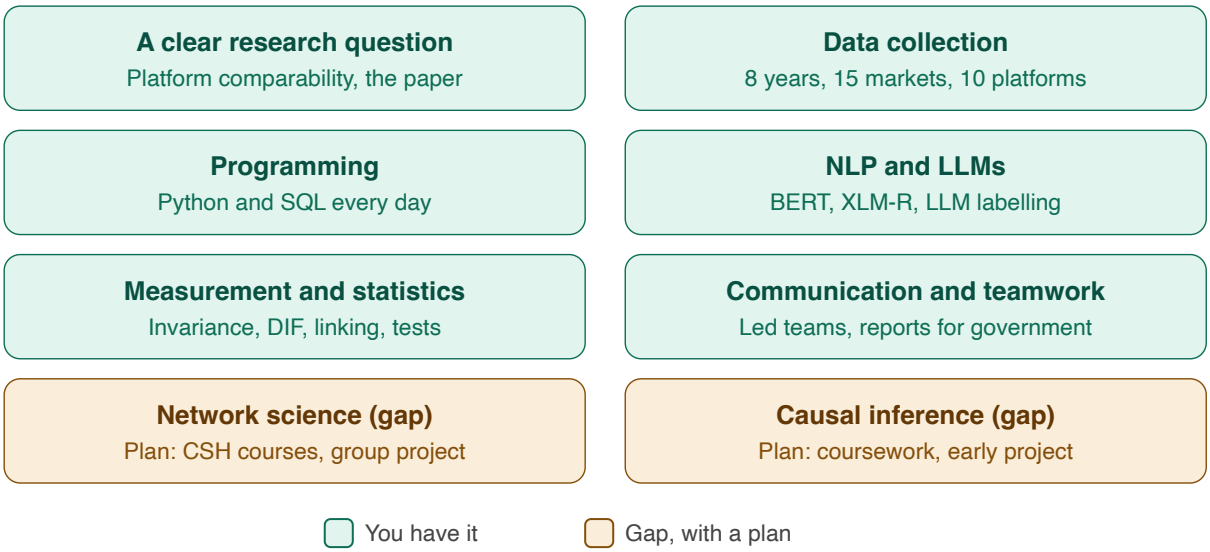
- **Fluency:** analyst on a twelve-month discourse study of 100,845 Brandwatch and 170,542 Reddit mentions with a BERTopic-derived codebook; LLM tagging with a prompt-version hash on every tag, three pilot runs on the same 500 rows; collection from ten platforms daily; a self-healing agent and a builder agent for collectors with approval gates; reports read by UK government communications teams.
- **Artemis AI:** 3 million+ Facebook and Instagram comments with image and video understanding (OCR, CLIP, Whisper); Claude labels about 6,000 posts with an explanation each, rules mined from them prompt DeepSeek, whose labels train XLM-R, DistilBERT and DeBERTa classifiers; the team hand-labelled about 500 posts to check both models; storm detection and banter and dialect filters; you lead the technology in a team of eight towards the December beta.
- **Say it in one sentence:** “Brands and governments act on machine-labelled numbers that are rarely checked against people; my PhD question is how to check them.”

4. What you told CSH (keep answers consistent)

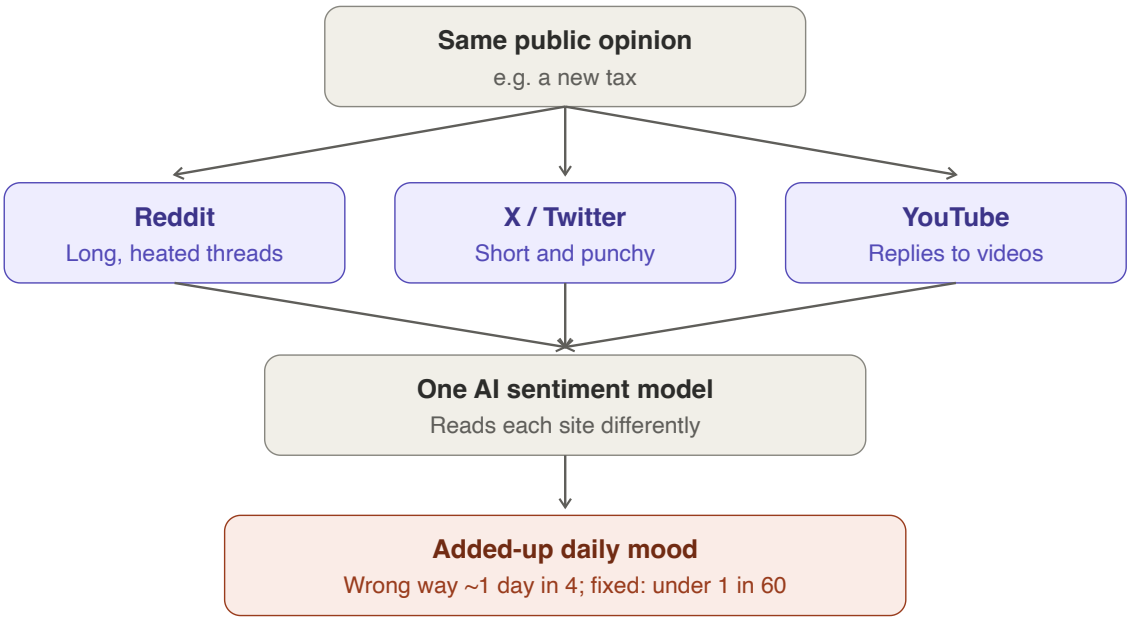


- **Q1, your project:** dissertation on UK economic policy reaction, 255,446 comments from X, Reddit, YouTube and Quora, ethics approval, BERT against BiLSTM and VADER, calibration, McNemar, bootstrap, Prophet, NRC emotions, LIME. What went wrong: BERT's macro-F1 of 0.878 was scored against VADER-seeded labels and the 200-post check reviewed VADER's labels, so validation was circular; and you had assumed "negative" means the same on every platform. Lesson: an agreement score describes the reference as much as the model.
- **Q2, CSH discovery:** Chen, Kmetty, Iñiguez and Omodei (2025, *Communication Methods and Measures*): linking a Hungarian survey to donated YouTube histories shows commenters are more polarised and selective than watchers, so comment-based studies overstate division. Your question: is the commenter–watcher gap stable enough that a small donated panel could calibrate polarisation estimates from public comments at scale?
- **Q3, your problem:** when is a machine-labelled construct (sentiment, stance, frame) comparable across platforms, annotator models and time, and how to correct it before tracking narrative spread. Tractable because (1) the simulation runs in seconds and can add models and time as facets, (2) you can build a corpus around events fixed in advance with a hand-labelled sample per platform and a second coder, (3) concept erasure tests whether removing the platform signal removes real differences, (4) corrected and uncorrected measures go into a network diffusion analysis. Closest to Alexander Hoyle's work; between the narratives-at-scale and polarisation springboard projects. Gap: network science of diffusion.

5. What a PhD needs, and what you bring



6. Your paper in 20 seconds



“AI reads opinions differently on Reddit than on YouTube, because people write differently on each. So adding platforms together can flip the answer: in my simulation, the overall mood points the wrong way on nearly a quarter of days, and under one day in sixty once each platform is corrected. The paper gives a checklist to test whether a comparison is fair, and a way to fix it.”

7. Practice answers (45–75 seconds each)

Tell us about yourself.
I'm a data engineer and researcher from Pakistan, and I work on social media data. I started web scraping on Fiverr as a computer science student, did more than 300 projects, then built Dubizzle Labs' first scraping system across 15 markets in four languages and was promoted twice. A Chevening Scholarship took me to Portsmouth for an MSc in Data Analytics, where my dissertation compared public reaction to UK economic policy across four platforms. Today I work on social media analysis at M+C Saatchi Fluency in London, for brands and UK government, and I'm co-founder and CTO of Artemis AI. Last week my first paper, with my supervisor, went live on arXiv.

Describe a research project and what went wrong.
Use section 4, Q1: the project, the circular validation you found yourself, the paper it became, the quarter-of-days result, and the lesson about independent yardsticks.

What have you built in industry, and what did it teach you?
Use section 3: one Fluency example (prompt-versioned LLM tagging), one Artemis AI example (explained labels, dialect and banter filters), then the one-sentence thread.

Why a PhD, and why now?
Industry taught me to collect and label online data at scale; it didn't teach me to show rigorously what those numbers say about people. Publishing the paper showed me this is the work I enjoy most, and I want the training to do it properly, then carry it back into how these tools are built.

Why CSH, and why complexity science?
Opinion online is a system, not a pile of posts: people, platforms and algorithms shape each other, and what we can see is a selected slice. Chen and colleagues showed commenters are more polarised than watchers, which is my problem in another form. Alexander Hoyle's validation work is closest to mine, and I want to learn network science and diffusion, which I don't have yet.

What would you work on?
Use section 4, Q3, in three steps: extend the simulation, build an event-anchored corpus labelled by several LLMs with human checks, then show when diffusion conclusions change after correction.

Strengths and gaps?
Use section 5: name two strengths with evidence, then the two gaps and how you will close them.

Teamwork, a setback, five years?
Team: led three at Dubizzle and three at VendueTech, lead the technology in a team of eight at Artemis AI. Setback: the circular validation. Five years: researching how online opinion is measured, so the numbers people act on are tested against people.

Questions for us? (one only)
How are students matched with supervisors in the first year, and is co-supervision across groups common?

8. On the day

- Join at **8:35 pm Lahore**; test Zoom, camera and microphone; quiet room, light in front of you, look at the camera.
- Keep this pack open but do not read from it. Answer the question, then stop. A short pause before answering is fine.
- Same facts as your application: 255,446 comments; team of eight at Artemis AI; arXiv 2610.16757; MSc Distinction, Chevening 2024/25.
- Recording is normal; only object at the start if you do not consent.

9. If you pass: Stage 2 (7–14 January)

You will present a paper chosen by the committee. Past papers: 2026 Clauset, Moore and Newman, "Hierarchical structure and the prediction of missing links in networks" (*Nature* 2008); Couzin et al., "Uninformed individuals promote democratic consensus in animal groups" (*Science* 2011); 2025 Albert, Jeong and Barabási, "Error and attack tolerance of complex networks" (*Nature* 2000); 2024 Watts and Strogatz, "Collective dynamics of small-world networks" (*Nature* 1998). CSH's advice: read carefully, google, work through the equations or code, and be ready to explain methods, results, conclusions and critiques. Start reading these after Tuesday.

Sources: CSH Graduate Program FAQ (csh.ac.at/education/dis-faq); CSH invitation email of 14 Oct 2026; AcademicPositions, "The 5 most important questions you'll be asked during a PhD interview"; Researcher.Life, "PhD admission interview questions and how to answer them"; your CSH answers and CV (13 Oct 2026).